

FULL-DAY EMERGENCY SUB PLANS

THREE WHOLE DAYS

3
FULL DAYS



Complete elementary sub plans for grades 3 to 5.
Not a worksheet. An entire day, from the first
bell to dismissal.



- ✓ Three complete school days, arrival to dismissal
- ✓ Reading, writing, math and science every single day
- ✓ A minute-by-minute schedule the substitute can follow
- ✓ Time fillers, brain breaks and indoor recess included
- ✓ Full answer keys, and nothing to prepare



From the
first bell to
dismissal! ♥



READING



WRITING



MATH



SCIENCE



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How This Pack Works

START HERE

Most sub plans give a substitute one activity and hope. That works for a middle school teacher covering a single period. It does not work in an elementary classroom, where the substitute has the same thirty children from arrival until dismissal and has to fill **every minute** of it.

This pack contains three complete days. Each one covers reading, writing, math and science, plus morning work, a morning meeting, transitions, and a closing reflection. Print it once, put it in a drawer, and you are covered for three absences.

What each day contains

PAGES	WHAT IT IS	WHO IT IS FOR
1	Day at a Glance. The entire day in one table, with times, what happens, and which page the students need in front of them.	The substitute. Keep it.
1	Morning Work. Word work and a number warm-up for students to start on as they arrive.	Copy for students.
1	Morning Meeting and First Moves. The exact words to say, plus three phrases that hold a class you do not know.	The substitute. Keep it.
3	Reading block. A passage written for this pack, comprehension questions, and a go further page.	Copy for students.
2	Writing block. A model, a planning frame, and a draft page.	Copy for students.
3	Math block. A worked example, practice, and a challenge.	Copy for students.
2	Afternoon science. A content page and a task page.	Copy for students.
1	End of Day Reflection. What students tell the returning teacher about the day.	Copy for students.
2	Answer keys. Every answer worked out, with marking notes.	The substitute. Keep them.

SIXTEEN PAGES PER DAY. TWELVE TO COPY, FOUR TO KEEP.

That sounds like a lot until you remember it is an entire school day. A regular teacher gets through more than that before lunch.

Copy each day as one stapled packet. Hand it out in the morning and students work through it in order. That single decision removes most of the transitions where an unfamiliar class comes apart.

Substitute Quick Start

FOR THE SUBSTITUTE

If you have five minutes before the children arrive, read this page and nothing else. It is enough to run the day.

IN THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

1. Find the Day at a Glance page for whichever day the teacher left. Put it on the desk and keep it there.
2. Check the packets are copied. If they are not, copy the Morning Work page first and the rest during morning work.
3. Write your name on the board.
4. Read the Morning Meeting script. Do not improvise the first minute.

The shape of every day in this pack

ROUGHLY	WHAT HAPPENS
Arrival	Morning work at desks. You take attendance while they work, which is exactly why it exists.
Morning meeting	Ten minutes. Introduce yourself, name the plan for the day, take two questions.
Morning blocks	Reading, then writing, then math. The heaviest thinking goes earliest on purpose.
After lunch	Twenty minutes of quiet reading, then the science block. Afternoons are calmer by design.
Last ten minutes	The End of Day Reflection sheet, then pack up.

THREE THINGS THAT MATTER MORE THAN THE LESSONS

Give a finish time, not a page count. "Pens down at ten past" works. "Finish page three" starts a negotiation.

Ask students to show you the routines. Where they line up, how they hand things in, what happens at recess. They know, they enjoy telling you, and it makes them your allies rather than your auditors.

Never threaten anything you cannot do. You are here for one day. "Your teacher will see this" is true and sufficient.

IF A CHILD ASKS SOMETHING YOU CANNOT ANSWER

"Write it down and put a star next to it, and your teacher will look at the starred ones." This is always true, always accepted, and genuinely useful to the teacher who comes back.

The Three Days

THE THREE DAYS

Each day is completely independent. Leave them in any order. No day assumes anything from another, or from where your class has reached in its own program.

DAY	THEME	READING	WRITING	MATH
1	Animals That Solve Problems	Informational text and citing evidence	Opinion writing	Multiplication, arrays and area
2	Building Big	Informational text and cause and effect	Explanatory writing	Perimeter and measurement
3	The Day the Sky Turned Green	Narrative fiction and inference	Narrative writing	Fractions and reading data

Afternoon science

DAY	TOPIC	WHAT STUDENTS DO
1	Adaptations	Match five birds' beaks to the food each one handles, then correct a common wrong idea about why animals change.
2	Forces and shapes	Test a sheet of paper in four shapes, then work out why triangles and arches are strong.
3	Weather and the water cycle	Name each stage of the cycle, including the one most diagrams leave out.

WHICH DAY SHOULD I LEAVE?

A class you do not know at all: Day 1. The reading is the most engaging of the three and the math is the most straightforward.

You want work you can grade when you return: Day 2. The explanatory writing shows you clearly who can and cannot connect cause to effect.

A restless group, or a Friday: Day 3. The story pulls them in and the writing task has a low entry point.

Three days out in a row: Leave them in order. The subjects rotate so nothing feels repetitive.

Class Information

TEACHER • FILL THIS IN ONCE AT THE START OF THE YEAR

Complete this page once and it works for every absence after that. It answers the questions a substitute would otherwise have to interrupt a neighboring class to ask.

THE BASICS

My name and grade _____

Room number _____

Teach this day _____ Day _____ or any day from the index

Teacher next door _____

Office extension _____

THE DAY

Bell times _____

Recess and lunch _____

Specials today _____

Which, when, who takes them _____

Bathroom routine _____

Where the class lines up _____

Fire drill point _____

THE CHILDREN

Leave early or arrive late _____

Medical, allergies, medication _____

Who holds it and where _____

Accommodations _____

Seating, extra time, reader, movement breaks _____

Students who can help you _____

Genuinely the most useful line on this page _____

Anything else _____

Holding a Class You Do Not Know

SUBSTITUTE · KEEP THIS PAGE

YOU ARE NOT GOING TO WIN BY BEING STRICT

A class that does not know you will test where the edges are. That is normal, it is not personal, and it happens in the first twenty minutes. Nothing settles a room faster than being warm and completely clear about what happens next.

Say this instead of that

INSTEAD OF	TRY
"Be quiet!"	"Voices off, eyes here, and I will tell you what happens next."
"Who was talking?"	"I am waiting for one more table." Then wait. Naming a child hands them the room.
"Sit down NOW."	"I need everyone in a seat before I can start. Any seat that works."
"Because I said so."	"Your teacher left this for today, so this is what we are doing."
"You always do this."	"That is not going to work today. Try again." You cannot know what they always do.
"Stop it or else."	Never threaten what you cannot deliver. "Your teacher will see this" is enough.

Four moves that work in any elementary room

- **Pick one quiet signal in the first ten minutes.** Raising your hand and waiting works everywhere and needs no equipment. Teach it once while things are calm and it will work when they are not.
- **Count down instead of asking twice.** "Packets away in five, four, three..." moves a room faster than any instruction repeated.
- **Give the loud one a job.** Handing out packets, collecting work, holding the door. It is not a reward, it is redirection, and it works.
- **Narrate what is going right.** "Table three is ready." The rest of the room copies it within seconds and nobody has been told off.

WHEN SOMETHING GOES PROPERLY WRONG

If a child is hurt, distressed, or a situation is beyond a normal classroom problem, send two students to the office or the teacher next door. Do not leave the class. Do not try to manage it alone because you want to seem capable.

Write one line about it on the substitute's note at the back of this pack. One line. Not a report.

What Is on Every Page

EVERY PAGE IN THIS PACK

Twelve pages per day are copied for students. Four are kept by the substitute. This table tells you which is which without opening anything.

PAGE	WHAT IT IS	CONTENTS
1-7	Getting started	Cover, how the pack works, substitute quick start, the three days, class information template, holding a class you do not know, this page
8	Day 1 at a Glance	The whole day in one table. <i>Substitute keeps this.</i>
9-21	Day 1 student pages	Morning work, informational text and citing evidence, opinion writing, multiplication, arrays and area, adaptations, and the End of Day Reflection
10	Day 1 morning script	The words to say for the first twenty minutes. <i>Substitute keeps this.</i>
22-23	Day 1 answer keys	Every answer, with marking notes. <i>Substitute keeps these.</i>
24	Day 2 at a Glance	The whole day in one table. <i>Substitute keeps this.</i>
25-37	Day 2 student pages	Morning work, informational text and cause and effect, explanatory writing, perimeter and measurement, forces and shapes, and the End of Day Reflection
26	Day 2 morning script	The words to say for the first twenty minutes. <i>Substitute keeps this.</i>
38-39	Day 2 answer keys	Every answer, with marking notes. <i>Substitute keeps these.</i>
40	Day 3 at a Glance	The whole day in one table. <i>Substitute keeps this.</i>
41-53	Day 3 student pages	Morning work, narrative fiction and inference, narrative writing, fractions and reading data, weather and the water cycle, and the End of Day Reflection
42	Day 3 morning script	The words to say for the first twenty minutes. <i>Substitute keeps this.</i>
54-55	Day 3 answer keys	Every answer, with marking notes. <i>Substitute keeps these.</i>
56-60	The filler banks	Time fillers, brain breaks, indoor recess, a fast finisher menu for students, and the substitute's note back
61-62	Reference	Standards alignment, terms of use and credits

THE FASTEST WAY TO USE THIS PACK

Photocopy the twelve student pages for one day as a single stapled packet. Put the four substitute pages on the desk. That is the entire preparation, and it takes about four minutes.

Day 1 at a Glance

SUBSTITUTE · KEEP THIS PAGE ON YOUR DESK

THE WHOLE DAY, IN ONE TABLE

Times are a guide. Your school's bells win. The **Page** column tells you which sheet the students need in front of them. Everything is in the order you will use it.

TIME	BLOCK	WHAT HAPPENS	PAGE
8:30	Arrival	Students come in and start Morning Work at their desks. Take attendance while they work.	p. 9
8:50	Morning meeting	Read the script on the next page. Introduce yourself and the plan for the day.	keep
9:05	Reading	Students read the passage, then answer the questions. Read it aloud if the class is restless.	p. 11-12
9:50	Go further	Anyone finished moves to the Go Further page.	p. 13
10:05	Recess	Follow the school's routine. Ask a student to show you where the class lines up.	—
10:25	Writing	Plan first, then draft. Insist on the planning page before anyone writes sentences.	p. 14-15
11:10	Math	Read the worked example together, then the practice page.	p. 16-17
12:00	Lunch	Line them up two minutes early. It is always slower than you expect.	—
12:45	Quiet reading	Twenty minutes. Students read their own book. Anyone without one gets the Go Further page.	—
1:05	Science	Read the page together, then the task.	p. 19-20
1:50	Specials or filler	If there is no special, use the Time Filler Bank at the back.	back
2:35	Closing	End of Day Reflection sheet, then pack up.	p. 21
2:50	Dismissal	Stack all work on the teacher's desk with the reflection sheets on top.	—

IF YOU ARE RUNNING BEHIND

Cut the Go Further page and quiet reading first. Never cut the closing reflection: it takes eight minutes and it is the single most useful thing you can leave for the returning teacher.

IF YOU FINISH EARLY

Every block has a Fast Finisher box on the student page. Beyond that, the Time Filler Bank near the back of this pack has twelve activities that need nothing at all.

Morning Work

DO THIS QUIETLY AT YOUR DESK WHILE EVERYONE ARRIVES

You do not need to finish all of it. Start at the top and work down.

1. Word work

Write the missing letters, then use the finished word in a sentence of your own.

WORD WITH LETTERS MISSING	THE WHOLE WORD	MY SENTENCE
a d _ p t		
s u r v _ v e		
b e _ k		
c l e _ e r		
t o _ l		

2. Number warm-up

Fill in the missing number in each one.

	PROBLEM	ANSWER
1	$6 \times 7 = \underline{\quad}$	
2	$\underline{\quad} \times 4 = 32$	
3	$9 \times \underline{\quad} = 54$	
4	$45 \div 5 = \underline{\quad}$	
5	Double 17, then add 6	
6	What is 100 minus 63?	

3. One-minute challenge

Betty the crow used a tool. Write down three tools you have already used today. A tool is anything you use to do a job, so a spoon counts.

4. READY TO GO?

Turn your page over and read quietly until everyone is finished. If you do not have a book, draw an animal you think is clever and label three things about it.

Morning Meeting and First Moves

SUBSTITUTE • KEEP THIS PAGE

THE FIRST TWENTY MINUTES DECIDE THE DAY

You are a stranger to this class and they are testing the edges. Being warm and completely clear about what happens next is worth more than any rule you could announce.

Morning meeting, ten minutes

SAY THIS TO START

Good morning everyone. My name is on the board. Your teacher is not here today and has left me everything we need, so nothing is a surprise. Here is the plan: reading, then writing, then math before lunch. After lunch we have something about animals that solve problems. I do not know your names yet, so I am going to get some of them wrong. Tell me kindly when I do.

Then, in this order

WHAT YOU DO	
1	Write your name on the board. Leave it there all day.
2	Read the script above. Do not improvise the first minute; a clear start buys you the whole morning.
3	Ask: <i>who can tell me one thing this class always does in the morning?</i> Take two answers only, then move on. Students love correcting a substitute and this gives them a legitimate way to do it.
4	Point at the day's plan and say what happens before recess. Children settle when they know the shape of the day.
5	Hand out the reading pages and begin.

Three things that hold a class you do not know

INSTEAD OF	SAY THIS
"Stop talking."	"Voices off, eyes here, and I will tell you what happens next."
"Sit down."	"I need everyone in a seat before I can start. Take any seat that works."
"Who is being noisy?"	"I am waiting for one more table." Then wait. Do not name anyone.
"Because I said so."	"Your teacher left this for today, so this is what we are doing."

THE ONE SIGNAL TO TEACH THEM EARLY

Pick a quiet signal in the first ten minutes and use it all day. Raising your hand and waiting works in every classroom and needs no equipment. Tell them what it means once, use it once while things are calm, and it will work when things are not.

Reading: The Bird That Made a Hook

BEFORE YOU READ

This is a true story about a bird. As you read, look for the moment the scientist realized something surprising. Paragraphs are numbered so the questions can point you straight to the right place.

The Bird That Made a Hook

A true story

- 1 In a laboratory in England, a scientist named Alex Kacelnik was studying a crow named Betty. Betty came from the island of New Caledonia, where the crows are famous for using sticks to poke insects out of holes.
- 2 The experiment was simple. A small bucket of food sat at the bottom of a clear tube. The bucket had a handle. Next to the tube, the scientists left two pieces of wire: one wire was already bent into a hook, and the other was perfectly straight.
- 3 The idea was to see whether Betty would choose the hooked wire. Choosing the right tool would already be clever.
- 4 Then something went wrong with the plan. Another crow, named Abel, grabbed the hooked wire and flew off with it. Betty was left alone with the straight piece of wire and a bucket she could not reach.
- 5 The scientists watched. Betty looked at the wire. She pushed one end of it into a gap at the edge of the table, wedged it there, and pulled. The wire bent. She lifted it out, and now she was holding a hook.
- 6 Then she lowered her new hook into the tube, caught the handle of the bucket, and pulled her food up.
- 7 Nobody had taught her this. Betty had never seen a person bend a wire. She had not been rewarded for bending anything before. She had a problem, and she changed an object to solve it.
- 8 The scientists ran the test again. And again. Betty bent wire into hooks nine times out of ten. When they gave her a piece of wire that was already hooked, she used it as it was. When they gave her a straight one, she bent it. She was not repeating a trick. She was looking at what she had and deciding what to do with it.
- 9 For a long time, people believed that making a tool was something only humans did. Betty was a crow in a laboratory who had never been to school, and she worked it out in less than a minute.

Reading Questions

Answer in the space given. The paragraph numbers in the questions tell you exactly where to look.

1 What was Betty trying to reach, and what was in her way? (par. 2)

2 The scientists' plan went wrong. What happened? (par. 4)

3 Explain in your own words how Betty made a hook. (par. 5)

Write it as steps if that helps.

4 Why were the scientists so surprised? (par. 7)

5 How do we know Betty was not just repeating a trick she had learned? (par. 8)

6 Find one word in the passage that means a thing you use to do a job. Write the word and the paragraph number.

GO FURTHER

TASK

Betty had one problem and one object. Now it is your turn. For each problem below, describe a tool you could make from the objects listed. Draw it if that helps.

THE PROBLEM	WHAT YOU HAVE	WHAT YOU WOULD MAKE
A ball is stuck under a low shelf	A ruler and some tape	
A key has fallen down a drain grate	String and a magnet	
You need to reach a book on a high shelf	A coat hanger and a chair	
Paper keeps blowing off your desk	A stone and an elastic band	

1 Which of your four tools do you think would work best? Why?

FAST FINISHER

Write three questions you would ask Betty if she could answer. Then write what you think she would say.

Writing: Plan It

WRITING BLOCK • STEP 1, PLAN IT

TODAY YOU ARE WRITING

An opinion paragraph. Some people say animals like Betty are **intelligent**. Others say they are just very good at learning. What do you think, and why?

What a good one looks like

I think crows are genuinely intelligent. In the passage, Betty was given a straight wire and no example to copy, and she bent it into a hook to lift the bucket. She had never seen anyone do this before. To me that is not learning a trick, because a trick would be the same every time, and Betty changed what she did depending on which wire she was given. Some people would say she was just lucky the first time. But she did it nine times out of ten, and luck does not work that often.

Your plan

Notes only. Do not write sentences yet.

PART	YOUR NOTES
My opinion One sentence. No "maybe".	
Reason 1	
Proof from the text A fact from the passage.	
Reason 2	
What someone who disagrees would say	
My answer to them	

Writing: Write It

WRITING BLOCK • STEP 2, WRITE IT

Write your opinion paragraph in full sentences, in the order you planned it. Aim for six to eight sentences.

BEFORE YOU HAND IT IN, CHECK THREE THINGS

Does your first sentence say what you think? Did you use at least one fact from the passage? Did you say what someone who disagrees would say, and answer them?

Math: Arrays and Area

MATH BLOCK · READ THIS TOGETHER

WHAT WE ARE DOING TODAY

A rectangle made of squares tells you a multiplication fact, and a multiplication fact tells you the area of a rectangle. They are the same idea wearing different clothes.

Worked example

A rectangle is 6 squares wide and 4 squares tall. What is its area?

Count one row: 6 squares. There are 4 rows. So instead of counting all of them one by one, multiply.

$6 \times 4 = 24$ square units

The word **area** just means how many squares fit inside. That is why the answer is written in **square** units.

Now backwards. A rectangle has an area of 24 square units and is 3 squares tall. How wide is it? Ask: 3 times what makes 24? The answer is 8, so it is 8 squares wide.

SUBSTITUTE: THE ONE THING TO SAY IF THEY ARE STUCK

Ask them to draw it. Almost every student who is stuck on area gets unstuck the moment they draw the rectangle and count one row.

Try these two together

	QUESTION	WORKING	ANSWER
A	A rectangle is 7 wide and 3 tall. What is its area?		
B	A rectangle has an area of 20 and is 4 tall. How wide is it?		

Math: Practice

Show your working. A right answer with no working is worth less than a wrong answer you can explain.

QUESTION	WORKING	ANSWER
1 A rectangle is 5 wide and 6 tall. Area?		
2 A rectangle is 9 wide and 4 tall. Area?		
3 A rectangle is 8 wide and 8 tall. Area?		
4 Area is 30, height is 5. How wide?		
5 Area is 42, width is 6. How tall?		
6 Area is 36, and it is a square. How wide?		
7 A classroom rug is 4 m wide and 7 m long. What area of floor does it cover?		
8 A garden bed is 3 m wide and 9 m long. A second bed is 5 m wide and 5 m long. Which covers more ground, and by how much?		

Math: Challenge

MATH CHALLENGE

THE FENCE PROBLEM

A farmer has **24 meters of fencing**. She wants to make a rectangular pen, and she wants the pen to hold as much space as possible. The fence has to go all the way around.

WIDTH	HEIGHT	FENCE USED (ALL 4 SIDES)	AREA INSIDE
1 m	11 m	24 m	
2 m	10 m	24 m	
3 m	9 m	24 m	
4 m	8 m	24 m	
5 m	7 m	24 m	
6 m	6 m	24 m	

1 Which pen holds the most space? Every one uses exactly the same amount of fence.

2 What do you notice about the shape of the best one?

FAST FINISHER

Draw every rectangle you can find with an area of exactly 36 square units, using whole numbers only. There are more than you think.

Science: Built for the Job

BEFORE YOU READ

Every animal has body parts that suit where it lives and what it eats. Scientists call these adaptations. As you read, match each beak to the food it handles best.

- 1 A beak is a tool, and different birds carry different tools. A bird cannot swap its beak for a better one, so the beak it has decides a great deal about how it lives.
- 2 A **hawk** has a short, sharp, hooked beak. It is built for tearing meat into pieces small enough to swallow. It would be useless for cracking a seed.
- 3 A **finch** has a short, thick, cone shaped beak that works like a nutcracker. It splits hard seeds open. It would be hopeless for reaching into a flower.
- 4 A **hummingbird** has a long, thin beak like a straw, for reaching deep inside flowers to drink nectar. It could not tear meat or crack a seed.
- 5 A **pelican** has a huge beak with a stretchy pouch underneath, which works like a net. It scoops fish and water together, then lets the water drain away.
- 6 A **heron** has a long, straight, sharp beak like a spear, for stabbing fish in shallow water.
- 7 Here is the important part. None of these birds chose its beak, and none of them can change it. A bird is born with the beak its parents had. Birds whose beaks happened to suit the food around them found more to eat, survived, and had chicks with the same kind of beak. Over a very long time, that is how each beak came to match its job so closely.

WORDS WORTH KNOWING

Adaptation a body part or behavior that suits where an animal lives.

Nectar the sweet liquid inside a flower.

Pouch a stretchy bag of skin.

Survive to stay alive.

Science: Built for the Job: Your Turn

TASK 1: MATCH THE TOOL

Draw a line from each beak to the food it handles best. One food is left over on purpose. Work out which bird from the page would eat it.

BIRD	WHAT ITS BEAK IS LIKE	BEST FOOD (WRITE THE LETTER)
Hawk		
Finch		
Hummingbird		
Pelican		

The foods: A. Nectar deep inside a flower B. A mouse C. Hard sunflower seeds D. A fish in shallow water, stabbed one at a time E. A whole school of small fish, scooped at once

1 Which food was left over, and which bird from the page would eat it?

2 A new bird is found. It has a very long, thin, curved beak. Based on the page, what do you think it eats, and why?

TASK 2: THINK CAREFULLY

A student says: "*The hummingbird grew a long beak because it wanted to reach the nectar.*" Paragraph 7 says this is not what happens. Explain what is wrong with the sentence.

FAST FINISHER

Design a bird for a place where the only food is insects hiding deep inside tree bark. Draw its beak and label two things about it.

End of Day Reflection

LAST TEN MINUTES

BEFORE YOU PACK UP

Fill this in on your own. Your teacher will read it tomorrow, so be honest. There are no wrong answers here.

1 One thing I learned today was...

2 One thing I found tricky was...

3 One thing I would tell a friend about today:

4 Something my teacher should know about today:

This is for anything at all. Good or bad.

A NOTE TO WHOEVER IS READING THIS

Thank you for looking after our class today. Please write your name here so we know who to thank:

Answer Key: Literacy

READING QUESTIONS

1. A small bucket of food at the bottom of a clear tube. The bucket was too deep for her to reach with her beak.
2. Another crow named Abel took the hooked wire and flew off with it, so Betty was left with only the straight wire.
3. She pushed one end of the wire into a gap at the edge of the table, held it there, and pulled until the wire bent into a hook.
Accept any answer with the three steps in the right order. Full credit does not need the word wedged.
4. Because nobody had taught her. She had never seen a person bend wire and had never been rewarded for it. She invented the solution herself.
5. Because she did it differently depending on what she was given. When the wire was already hooked she used it as it was; when it was straight she bent it. A trick would be the same every time.
This is the strongest question on the page. It asks students to use evidence to rule out an alternative explanation.
6. **Tool**, in paragraph 1 or 7. Accept **wire** or **hook** if the student explains their reasoning.

GO FURTHER AND WRITING

Go further: Open. Any workable tool with a sensible explanation earns full credit. Look for students who explain *why* the shape works, not just what it looks like.

MARKING THE WRITING IN TEN SECONDS

Look for three things only: an opinion in the first sentence, at least one fact from the passage, and a sentence answering the other side. The third is the one most students skip. If it is missing, write "what would someone who disagrees say?" in the margin.

IF YOU ONLY MARK ONE THING TODAY

Mark the writing. It is the only piece on the whole day that shows you how each student thinks, and it is the piece the returning teacher can act on fastest.

Everything else can be checked against this key in a few minutes, or simply stacked and left.

Answer Key: Math and Afternoon

MATH PRACTICE

	ANSWER	WORKING
A	21 square units	7×3
B	5 wide	$4 \times ? = 20$
1	30 square units	5×6
2	36 square units	9×4
3	64 square units	8×8
4	6 wide	$5 \times 6 = 30$
5	7 tall	$6 \times 7 = 42$
6	6 wide	$6 \times 6 = 36$
7	28 square meters	4×7
8	The 3 m by 9 m bed, by 2 square meters	$3 \times 9 = 27$ square meters. $5 \times 5 = 25$ square meters. $27 - 25 = 2$.

Challenge: Areas in order: 11, 20, 27, 32, 35, **36**. The 6 by 6 pen holds the most. It is a **square**. With a fixed amount of fencing, the closer a rectangle is to a square, the more area it holds. That surprises most students and is worth saying out loud.

AFTERNOON BLOCK

Matching: Hawk = **B** (a mouse). Finch = **C** (hard seeds). Hummingbird = **A** (nectar). Pelican = **E** (a whole school of fish).

Q1. **D** was left over. The **heron** would eat it, because its beak is a spear for stabbing one fish at a time.

Q2. Something it needs to reach into a narrow, deep space. Nectar in a long flower or insects in a curved hole are both excellent answers. Mark the reasoning, not the food.

Task 2. The bird did not grow a longer beak because it wanted one, and no individual bird's beak changed during its life. Birds are born with the beak their parents had. Birds whose beaks already suited the food found more to eat and had more chicks. *Wanting* has nothing to do with it.

LEAVE THIS FOR THE TEACHER

Stack the day's work on the desk with the End of Day Reflection sheets on top. Those are the most useful thing the returning teacher will read.

Day 2 at a Glance

SUBSTITUTE • KEEP THIS PAGE ON YOUR DESK

THE WHOLE DAY, IN ONE TABLE

Times are a guide. Your school's bells win. The **Page** column tells you which sheet the students need in front of them. Everything is in the order you will use it.

TIME	BLOCK	WHAT HAPPENS	PAGE
8:30	Arrival	Students come in and start Morning Work at their desks. Take attendance while they work.	p. 25
8:50	Morning meeting	Read the script on the next page.	keep
9:05	Reading	Students read the passage, then the questions.	p. 27-28
9:50	Go further	The bridge-testing activity. Paper only.	p. 29
10:05	Recess	Ask a student to show you where the class lines up.	—
10:25	Writing	An explanation. Plan first, then draft.	p. 30-31
11:10	Math	Perimeter. Worked example together, then practice.	p. 32-33
12:00	Lunch	Line them up two minutes early.	—
12:45	Quiet reading	Twenty minutes with their own book.	—
1:05	Science	Forces and shapes. Read together, then the task.	p. 35-36
1:50	Specials or filler	If there is no special, use the Time Filler Bank.	back
2:35	Closing	End of Day Reflection sheet, then pack up.	p. 37
2:50	Dismissal	Stack all work on the teacher's desk with the reflection sheets on top.	—

IF YOU ARE RUNNING BEHIND

Cut the Go Further page and quiet reading first. The math challenge can also go. Keep the closing reflection.

IF YOU FINISH EARLY

Every block has a Fast Finisher box on the student page. Beyond that, the Time Filler Bank near the back of this pack has twelve activities that need nothing at all.

Morning Work

DO THIS QUIETLY AT YOUR DESK WHILE EVERYONE ARRIVES

You do not need to finish all of it. Start at the top and work down.

1. Word work

Write the missing letters, then use the finished word in a sentence of your own.

WORD WITH LETTERS MISSING	THE WHOLE WORD	MY SENTENCE
br_dge		
str_ng		
supp_rt		
we_ght		
balan_e		

2. Number warm-up

Fill in the missing number in each one.

	PROBLEM	ANSWER
1	$8 \times 6 = \underline{\quad}$	
2	$\underline{\quad} \times 7 = 63$	
3	$72 \div 8 = \underline{\quad}$	
4	Add $25 + 25 + 25 + 25$	
5	What is half of 84?	
6	Which is longer: 300 cm or 2 m?	

3. One-minute challenge

Look around the room and find three triangles. Write down where each one is. If you cannot find three, write down where you looked.

4. READY TO GO?

Turn your page over and read quietly. If you do not have a book, draw a bridge and label three parts of it.

Morning Meeting and First Moves

SUBSTITUTE • KEEP THIS PAGE

THE FIRST TWENTY MINUTES DECIDE THE DAY

You are a stranger to this class and they are testing the edges. Being warm and completely clear about what happens next is worth more than any rule you could announce.

Morning meeting, ten minutes

SAY THIS TO START

Good morning. My name is on the board. Your teacher is away today and has left me everything we need, so nothing today is a surprise. Reading, writing and math before lunch. After lunch we are going to find out why bridges do not fall down, and you are going to test something with a piece of paper. I will get some of your names wrong. Tell me kindly when I do.

Then, in this order

WHAT YOU DO	
1	Write your name on the board and leave it there all day.
2	Read the script above exactly. A clear first minute buys you the whole morning.
3	Ask: <i>what does this class always do before you start work?</i> Take two answers, then move on.
4	Point at the plan and name what happens before recess.
5	Hand out the reading pages and begin.

Three things that hold a class you do not know

INSTEAD OF	SAY THIS
"Stop talking."	"Voices off, eyes here, and I will tell you what happens next."
"Sit down."	"I need everyone in a seat before I can start. Take any seat that works."
"Who is being noisy?"	"I am waiting for one more table." Then wait. Do not name anyone.
"Because I said so."	"Your teacher left this for today, so this is what we are doing."

THE ONE SIGNAL TO TEACH THEM EARLY

Pick a quiet signal in the first ten minutes and use it all day. Raising your hand and waiting works in every classroom and needs no equipment. Tell them what it means once, use it once while things are calm, and it will work when things are not.

Reading: The Bridge That Wobbled

BEFORE YOU READ

This is a true story about a bridge that moved when nobody expected it to. Watch for what the engineers had not thought about.

The Bridge That Wobbled

A true story

- 1 On a Saturday in June 2000, a brand new footbridge opened across the River Thames in London. It was called the Millennium Bridge. It was slim, silver and beautiful, and around ninety thousand people came to walk across it on the first day.
- 2 Within minutes, the bridge began to sway.
- 3 It was not a small wobble. The deck moved from side to side hard enough that people grabbed the handrails. Some stopped walking. Some sat down. By the end of the weekend the bridge was closed, and it stayed closed for almost two years.
- 4 The engineers were confused at first. They had tested the bridge carefully. It was easily strong enough to hold ninety thousand people. It was not going to fall down, and it never came close. The problem was not strength. It was something nobody had thought to test.
- 5 Here is what was happening. When a bridge sways even slightly, a person walking on it does something automatic: they widen their steps and shift their weight sideways to keep their balance. They do not decide to do it. Everybody does it.
- 6 And when hundreds of people do that at the same time on the same bridge, they all begin stepping sideways together, in time with each other, without ever agreeing to. Each of those steps gives the bridge another small push in the direction it was already going.
- 7 So a tiny sway made people step together, and people stepping together made a bigger sway, and a bigger sway made them step together even more. The bridge and the crowd were feeding each other.
- 8 The fix took two years and involved fitting thirty-seven dampers underneath the deck. A damper works like the shock absorber on a bicycle: it soaks up movement and turns it into heat instead of letting it build up.
- 9 The bridge reopened in 2002 and has been steady ever since. It is still there, and millions of people cross it every year without noticing anything at all.
- 10 Engineers now test every new footbridge for this exact problem. It has a name: synchronous lateral excitation. But most people who work on bridges just call it the wobbly bridge effect.

Reading Questions

Answer in the space given. The paragraph numbers in the questions tell you exactly where to look.

1 When did the Millennium Bridge open, and roughly how many people walked across it that first day? (par. 1)

2 Was the bridge in danger of falling down? Which paragraph tells you the answer?

3 What do people automatically do when a bridge sways? (par. 5)

4 Explain how a small sway turned into a big one. (par. 6-7)

Try to write it as a chain: first this, which caused this...

5 What is a damper, and what does it do? (par. 8)

6 The engineers tested the bridge carefully and still missed this. What does that tell you about testing?

Reading: Go Further

GO FURTHER

TASK: THE PAPER BRIDGE

You need one sheet of paper and two piles of books. Rest the paper across the gap between them to make a flat bridge. Then change the shape of the paper and test again. **Nothing else is needed.**

SHAPE OF THE PAPER	MY PREDICTION	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED
Flat		
Folded into a zigzag (like a fan)		
Rolled into a tube		
Folded into a U shape		

1 Which shape held the most? It is exactly the same paper every time, so what actually changed?

2 Where have you seen the zigzag shape used in real life?

FAST FINISHER

Write a short warning notice to put at the entrance of the Millennium Bridge in June 2000. Explain to walkers what is happening and what they should do.

Writing: Plan It

WRITING BLOCK • STEP 1, PLAN IT

TODAY YOU ARE WRITING

An explanation. Your job is to explain to someone who has never read the passage **why the Millennium Bridge wobbled and how it was fixed**. This is not a story and not an opinion. You are explaining how something works.

What a good one looks like

The Millennium Bridge wobbled because of the people walking on it. When a bridge sways a little, everyone walking on it widens their steps to stay balanced. They do not choose to do this. Because hundreds of people were doing it at the same time, they all stepped sideways together, and every one of those steps pushed the bridge further the way it was already leaning. This made the sway bigger, which made people step together even more. Engineers fixed it by fitting thirty-seven dampers under the deck, which soak up the movement and turn it into heat.

Your plan

Notes only. Do not write sentences yet.

PART	YOUR NOTES
What I am explaining One sentence.	
First thing that happens	
What that causes	
What that causes	
How it was fixed	
Words I will use because, so, which meant, as a result	

Writing: Write It

WRITING BLOCK • STEP 2, WRITE IT

Write your explanation in full sentences. Use the joining words from your plan: **because, so, which meant, as a result**. They are what turn a list into an explanation.

BEFORE YOU HAND IT IN, CHECK THREE THINGS

Could someone who never read the passage understand it? Did you use joining words like **because** and **so**? Did you explain how it was fixed?

Math: Perimeter

MATH BLOCK • READ THIS TOGETHER

WHAT WE ARE DOING TODAY

Perimeter is the distance all the way around the outside of a shape. If you walked around the edge of the playground, the distance you walked would be its perimeter.

Worked example

A rectangle is 8 m long and 5 m wide. What is its perimeter?

Walk around it in your head. Along the long side: 8. Down the short side: 5. Back along the other long side: 8. Up the other short side: 5.

$$8 + 5 + 8 + 5 = 26 \text{ meters}$$

There is a shortcut. Add one long side and one short side, then double it: $(8 + 5) \times 2 = 26$. Both ways are correct, so use whichever you find easier.

Careful. Perimeter is the distance *around*. Area is the space *inside*. Two shapes can have the same perimeter and completely different areas.

SUBSTITUTE: THE ONE THING TO SAY IF THEY ARE STUCK

Ask them to trace around the edge of the shape with a finger while counting out loud. Perimeter confusion nearly always disappears the moment they physically walk the outline.

Try these two together

	QUESTION	WORKING	ANSWER
A	A rectangle is 10 m long and 3 m wide. Perimeter?		
B	A square has sides of 7 cm. Perimeter?		

Math: Practice

Show your working. A right answer with no working is worth less than a wrong answer you can explain.

QUESTION	WORKING	ANSWER
1 A rectangle 9 cm by 4 cm. Perimeter?		
2 A square with sides of 12 m. Perimeter?		
3 A rectangle 15 m by 6 m. Perimeter?		
4 A rectangle has a perimeter of 20 cm and is 6 cm long. How wide is it?		
5 A square has a perimeter of 36 cm. How long is one side?		
6 A vegetable patch is 7 m by 7 m. How much fencing goes all the way around it?		
7 A rectangle is 6 cm by 2 cm. Write down BOTH its perimeter and its area, and label which is which.		
8 Shape A is 8 cm by 2 cm. Shape B is 5 cm by 5 cm. Which has the larger perimeter? Which has the larger area?		

MATH CHALLENGE

SAME PERIMETER, DIFFERENT SHAPE

Every rectangle below has a perimeter of exactly **16 cm**. Fill in the areas and see what happens.

LONG SIDE	SHORT SIDE	PERIMETER	AREA
7 cm	1 cm	16 cm	
6 cm	2 cm	16 cm	
5 cm	3 cm	16 cm	
4 cm	4 cm	16 cm	

- 1

Which one has the biggest area?
- 2

All four use exactly the same amount of edge. Explain, in your own words, why the areas are so different.

FAST FINISHER

Draw three different rectangles that all have a perimeter of 24 cm. Write the area of each one underneath.

Science: Why Shapes Are Strong

BEFORE YOU READ

You already tested this with a piece of paper this morning. Now find out why it worked.

- 1 A flat sheet of paper cannot hold up a pencil. Roll the same sheet into a tube and it can hold a stack of books. You did not add anything. You did not make it thicker. You changed its shape.
- 2 When something bends, the material on the outside of the bend gets **stretched** and the material on the inside gets **squashed**. A flat sheet bends easily because there is very little material fighting back.
- 3 Fold that sheet into a zigzag and something changes. To bend it now, you would have to stretch and squash the folds at the same time, and the folds get in each other's way. The paper resists. This is why corrugated cardboard, roof panels and metal fences are made of zigzags.
- 4 The **triangle** is the strongest simple shape in building. Push on the corner of a square made of sticks and it squashes flat into a diamond, because the corners can move. Push on the corner of a triangle and nothing happens: to change its shape, one of the sides would have to get longer or shorter, and sticks do not stretch.
- 5 That is why you see triangles everywhere in bridges, cranes, roofs and towers. A square frame with one stick added diagonally across it becomes two triangles, and it stops wobbling instantly.
- 6 The **arch** solves a different problem. Weight pushed down on the top of an arch is squeezed sideways and downward through the curve into the ground at each end. Stone is very good at being squashed and very bad at being stretched, which is why almost every stone bridge built before modern times is an arch.

WORDS WORTH KNOWING

Stretch to be pulled longer.

Squash to be pressed shorter.

Arch a curved shape that carries weight down into the ground.

Corrugated made of zigzag folds.

TASK 1: SPOT THE SHAPE

For each structure, write which shape does the work: **triangle**, **arch**, or **tube**. Then say why.

STRUCTURE	SHAPE	WHY THAT SHAPE HELPS
A crane on a building site		
An old stone bridge		
A bicycle frame		
A rolled-up poster		
The roof frame of a house		

TASK 2: FIX THE WOBBLE

Someone has built a square frame out of four sticks joined at the corners. It keeps squashing sideways into a diamond. They are allowed **one** extra stick. Draw where it should go, and explain in one sentence why that fixes it.

FAST FINISHER

Design a bridge across a river using only triangles. Draw it and count how many triangles you used.

End of Day Reflection

LAST TEN MINUTES

BEFORE YOU PACK UP

Fill this in on your own. Your teacher will read it tomorrow, so be honest. There are no wrong answers here.

1 One thing I learned today was...

2 One thing I found tricky was...

3 One question I still have is...

4 Something my teacher should know about today:

This is for anything at all. Good or bad.

A NOTE TO WHOEVER IS READING THIS

Thank you for looking after our class today. Please write your name here so we know who to thank:

Answer Key: Literacy

READING QUESTIONS

1. June 2000. About ninety thousand people crossed it on the first day.
2. **No.** Paragraph 4 says it was easily strong enough and never came close to falling. The problem was movement, not strength. *This one matters. Many students assume a wobbling bridge is about to collapse. The passage says plainly that it was not.*
3. They widen their steps and shift their weight sideways to keep their balance, without deciding to.
4. A small sway made people step sideways to balance. Because they all did it at once, they stepped in time with each other. Each of those steps pushed the bridge the way it was already going, so the sway got bigger, which made people step together even more. *Full credit needs the loop: the sway caused the stepping and the stepping caused more sway. A one-way answer earns half.*
5. A damper is fitted under the deck and works like a shock absorber on a bicycle. It soaks up movement and turns it into heat instead of letting it build up.
6. Open. Strong answers: you can only test for problems you have thought of; some problems only appear at full scale or with real crowds; testing one thing well does not mean you tested everything. *Any thoughtful answer earns credit. This question is worth reading aloud if two students disagree.*

GO FURTHER AND WRITING

Go further: The rolled tube and the zigzag hold far more than the flat sheet. Nothing about the paper changed except its shape. A flat sheet bends easily; a folded or curved one has to be squashed and stretched at the same time before it can bend, which is much harder. Students often name corrugated cardboard, roof panels or metal fencing for question 2.

MARKING THE WRITING IN TEN SECONDS

Look for joining words. An explanation without **because**, **so** or **which meant** is a list of facts, not an explanation. If they are missing, that is the one comment worth writing.

IF YOU ONLY MARK ONE THING TODAY

Mark the writing. It is the only piece on the whole day that shows you how each student thinks, and it is the piece the returning teacher can act on fastest.

Everything else can be checked against this key in a few minutes, or simply stacked and left.

Answer Key: Math and Afternoon

MATH PRACTICE

ANSWER	WORKING
A 26 m	$10 + 3 + 10 + 3$
B 28 cm	7×4
1 26 cm	$9 + 4 + 9 + 4$
2 48 m	12×4
3 42 m	$(15 + 6) \times 2$
4 4 cm wide	$20 - 12 = 8$, then $8 \div 2$
5 9 cm	$36 \div 4$
6 28 m of fencing	7×4
7 Perimeter 16 cm, area 12 square cm	$(6+2) \times 2$ and 6×2 . Watch the labels.
8 A has the larger perimeter (20 cm vs 20 cm — they are equal). B has the larger area, 25 vs 16.	This is the trap. Both perimeters are 20 cm. Students who assume the longer shape must have the bigger perimeter get caught.

Challenge: Areas: 7, 12, 15, **16**. The 4 by 4 square has the biggest area. With the same perimeter, the closer a rectangle gets to a square, the more space it holds. The long thin one wastes its edge on length instead of wrapping around space.

AFTERNOON BLOCK

Task 1: Crane = **triangle**, the frame is made of them so it cannot squash. Stone bridge = **arch**, weight is squeezed down the curve and stone is strong when squashed. Bicycle frame = **triangle**, for the same reason as the crane. Rolled poster = **tube**, the curve makes it hard to bend. House roof = **triangle**, roof trusses are triangles.

Task 2: The stick goes **diagonally from one corner to the opposite corner**. It turns the square into two triangles. A triangle cannot change shape without a side getting longer or shorter, so the frame can no longer squash.

LEAVE THIS FOR THE TEACHER

Stack the day's work on the desk with the End of Day Reflection sheets on top. Those are the most useful thing the returning teacher will read.

Day 3 at a Glance

SUBSTITUTE • KEEP THIS PAGE ON YOUR DESK

THE WHOLE DAY, IN ONE TABLE

Times are a guide. Your school's bells win. The **Page** column tells you which sheet the students need in front of them. Everything is in the order you will use it.

TIME	BLOCK	WHAT HAPPENS	PAGE
8:30	Arrival	Students come in and start Morning Work. Take attendance while they work.	p. 41
8:50	Morning meeting	Read the script on the next page.	keep
9:05	Reading	A short story today rather than a fact page. Reading it aloud works very well.	p. 43-44
9:50	Go further	Point of view task.	p. 45
10:05	Recess	Ask a student where the class lines up.	—
10:25	Writing	A short story of their own, using a frame.	p. 46-47
11:10	Math	Fractions and reading a graph.	p. 48-49
12:00	Lunch	Line them up two minutes early.	—
12:45	Quiet reading	Twenty minutes with their own book.	—
1:05	Science	Weather and the water cycle.	p. 51-52
1:50	Specials or filler	If there is no special, use the Time Filler Bank.	back
2:35	Closing	End of Day Reflection sheet, then pack up.	p. 53
2:50	Dismissal	Stack all work on the desk with the reflection sheets on top.	—

IF YOU ARE RUNNING BEHIND

Cut quiet reading and the math challenge first. If the writing block is going well, let it run long and shorten math to the practice page only.

IF YOU FINISH EARLY

Every block has a Fast Finisher box on the student page. Beyond that, the Time Filler Bank near the back of this pack has twelve activities that need nothing at all.

Morning Work

DO THIS QUIETLY AT YOUR DESK WHILE EVERYONE ARRIVES

You do not need to finish all of it. Start at the top and work down.

1. Word work

Write the missing letters, then use the finished word in a sentence of your own.

WORD WITH LETTERS MISSING	THE WHOLE WORD	MY SENTENCE
thund_r		
evap_rate		
shelt_r		
forec_st		
cl_mate		

2. Number warm-up

Fill in the missing number in each one.

	PROBLEM	ANSWER
1	Half of $\frac{3}{4}$ of a pizza is ____ of a pizza	
2	$\frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{4} =$ ____	
3	Which is bigger: $\frac{1}{2}$ or $\frac{2}{5}$?	
4	$7 \times 8 =$ ____	
5	$120 \div 4 =$ ____	
6	What is $\frac{1}{3}$ of 27?	

3. One-minute challenge

Write down four words that describe the weather outside right now. Try not to use hot, cold, wet or dry.

4. READY TO GO?

Turn your page over and read quietly. If you do not have a book, draw the weather outside the window right now and write three words describing it.

Morning Meeting and First Moves

SUBSTITUTE • KEEP THIS PAGE

THE FIRST TWENTY MINUTES DECIDE THE DAY

You are a stranger to this class and they are testing the edges. Being warm and completely clear about what happens next is worth more than any rule you could announce.

Morning meeting, ten minutes

SAY THIS TO START

Good morning. My name is on the board. Your teacher is away today and left me a full plan, so nothing today is a surprise. This morning we have a story, some writing and some math. This afternoon we are finding out where rain actually comes from, and the answer is stranger than most people think. I will get some names wrong. Correct me kindly.

Then, in this order

WHAT YOU DO	
1	Write your name on the board and leave it there.
2	Read the script above exactly.
3	Ask: <i>what is one thing this class always does in the morning?</i> Two answers, then move on.
4	Name what happens before recess.
5	Hand out the reading pages and begin. This one reads aloud well if you want to.

Three things that hold a class you do not know

INSTEAD OF	SAY THIS
"Stop talking."	"Voices off, eyes here, and I will tell you what happens next."
"Sit down."	"I need everyone in a seat before I can start. Take any seat that works."
"Who is being noisy?"	"I am waiting for one more table." Then wait. Do not name anyone.
"Because I said so."	"Your teacher left this for today, so this is what we are doing."

THE ONE SIGNAL TO TEACH THEM EARLY

Pick a quiet signal in the first ten minutes and use it all day. Raising your hand and waiting works in every classroom and needs no equipment. Tell them what it means once, use it once while things are calm, and it will work when things are not.

Reading: The Day the Sky Turned Green

BEFORE YOU READ

Today's reading is a story, not a fact page. As you read, notice how Priya feels and what makes her feel that way. Nothing in the story says how she feels directly.

The Day the Sky Turned Green

A short story

- 1 Priya noticed the light first. It was half past two on a Thursday and the classroom had gone the color of pond water. Everything looked wrong. Mr. Oyelaran's white shirt looked green. The pages of her book looked green.
- 2 Nobody else had looked up yet. She kept writing, but she had stopped reading her own handwriting.
- 3 Then the wind stopped. Not softened. It stopped completely, and the flagpole rope outside, which had been slapping against the metal all afternoon, went silent. In the quiet Priya could hear somebody's pencil rolling across a desk two rows over.
- 4 Mr. Oyelaran put down his marker and walked to the window without saying anything. He stood there for four seconds. Priya counted them.
- 5 "Everybody," he said, in exactly the same voice he used for handing back tests, "leave your things where they are and line up at the door."
- 6 Nobody argued, which had never happened before.
- 7 The hallway was full of classes moving the same direction, and every teacher was using that same flat, ordinary voice. Priya's hands were cold. She put them in her sleeves and kept walking. Ahead of her, Marcus kept turning around to look at her and then turning back without saying anything.
- 8 They sat along the interior wall of the gym, away from every window, with their knees up and their arms over their heads the way they had practiced twice a year since kindergarten and never once meant.
- 9 The sound arrived after eleven minutes. Priya knew it was eleven because she counted the whole way, in her head, in groups of ten. It was not the freight train sound people always describe. It was more like standing too close to a very large waterfall.
- 10 It lasted about forty seconds.
- 11 Then it was gone, and there was a long strange minute where nobody moved because nobody had told them to.
- 12 The tornado had passed a mile and a half north of the school and taken the roof off a farm supply store. Nobody was hurt. It was on the news for two days and then it was not.
- 13 Priya's mother collected her at four. In the car she asked if Priya had been frightened, and Priya said no.
- 14 That night she counted the seconds between the flash and the thunder of an ordinary, harmless storm forty miles away, over and over, until she fell asleep.

Reading Questions

Answer in the space given. The paragraph numbers in the questions tell you exactly where to look.

1 Write down three things Priya notices that tell her something is wrong. (par. 1-3)

2 Why does Mr. Oyelaran use "exactly the same voice he used for handing back tests"? (par. 5)

3 Paragraph 6 says nobody argued, "which had never happened before." What does that tell you about how the class was feeling?

4 In paragraph 13, Priya tells her mother she was not frightened. Do you believe her? Use paragraph 14 in your answer.

This is the most important question on the page.

5 The story never uses the word scared. Find one thing Priya does that shows she is scared without saying it.

Reading: Go Further

GO FURTHER

TASK: THE SAME DAY, SOMEBODY ELSE

Retell part of this day from **Mr. Oyelaran's** point of view. Same events, same facts. What changes is what he notices and what he is worried about.

BEFORE YOU WRITE, THINK

He is responsible for twenty-six children. He can see out of the window. He has done this drill many times and has never needed it. Everything he says out loud has to sound calm.

1 What is the biggest difference between his version and Priya's? Not the facts. The feeling.

FAST FINISHER

Write the two-sentence news report about this day. Then write the two sentences Priya would write in her diary. Notice how different they are.

Writing: Plan It

WRITING BLOCK • STEP 1, PLAN IT

TODAY YOU ARE WRITING

A short story of your own about **a day when something changed suddenly**. It does not have to be dangerous. A power cut, a cancelled trip, an unexpected visitor, or a fire drill in the rain all work.

What a good one looks like

The lights went out during the spelling test. For about two seconds nobody said anything at all. Then everybody said everything at once. Mrs. Fenner found a torch in her desk and told us to stay in our seats, which we did for almost a whole minute. Dylan said it was probably the whole city. It was actually just our building, and it came back on before lunch. But for eleven minutes we sat in the half dark and nobody once asked about the spelling test.

Your plan

Notes only. Do not write sentences yet.

PART	YOUR NOTES
Where and when	
What was normal at first	
What suddenly changed	
What people did	
How it ended	
One small detail I will include	
A sound, a color, or something someone said.	

Writing: Write It

WRITING BLOCK • STEP 2, WRITE IT

Write your story in full sentences. Try to do what the author of today's story did: **show** how people felt instead of naming the feeling. Do not write "I was scared." Write what you did instead.

BEFORE YOU HAND IT IN, CHECK THREE THINGS

Does something actually change in your story? Did you include one small detail a reader could see or hear? Did you avoid naming feelings directly?

Math: Fractions and a Graph

MATH BLOCK · READ THIS TOGETHER

WHAT WE ARE DOING TODAY

This morning's story was about weather. This afternoon's science is about weather. So today's math uses real-looking rainfall figures, and you will need fractions to make sense of them.

Worked example

In one week it rained on 3 days out of 7. What fraction of the week was rainy?

The bottom number of a fraction is how many parts there are altogether. The top number is how many of them you are talking about.

3/7 of the week was rainy

Now a comparison. Which is more, 1/2 of a week or 3/7 of a week? Half of 7 days is 3 and a half. So 3 days is less than half. That means 3/7 is less than 1/2.

A quick trick: double the top number. If doubling it gives you less than the bottom number, the fraction is less than a half. Double 3 is 6, and 6 is less than 7, so 3/7 is under a half.

SUBSTITUTE: THE ONE THING TO SAY IF THEY ARE STUCK

Ask: how many would be exactly half? Then compare. Almost every fraction comparison at this level gets easier the moment students work out the halfway point first.

Try these two together

	QUESTION	WORKING	ANSWER
A	It rained on 5 days out of 10. What fraction? Is that more or less than half?		
B	Which is bigger, 2/5 or 1/2?		

Math: Practice

Show your working. A right answer with no working is worth less than a wrong answer you can explain.

QUESTION	WORKING	ANSWER
1 It rained 4 days out of 8. What fraction of the week?		
2 Is $\frac{3}{8}$ more or less than a half? How do you know?		
3 Is $\frac{5}{9}$ more or less than a half?		
4 Put these in order, smallest first: $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{1}{4}$, $\frac{3}{4}$		
5 A class of 24 students. $\frac{1}{3}$ walk to school. How many walk?		
6 Of the same 24 students, $\frac{1}{4}$ come by bus. How many is that?		
7 Using the rainfall graph below, which month had the most rain, and how much?		
8 How much more rain fell in the wettest month than in the driest?		

Math: Challenge

MATH CHALLENGE

RAINFALL, ONE TOWN, SIX MONTHS

Use this table for questions 7 and 8 on the practice page, then answer the questions below.

JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN
40 mm	30 mm	60 mm	80 mm	50 mm	20 mm

1 What is the total rainfall for all six months?

2 April had 80 mm. What fraction of the six-month total fell in April? Write it as a fraction, then simplify it if you can.

3 A newspaper writes: "Rainfall doubled between February and March." Is that true? Show your working.

FAST FINISHER

Draw a bar chart of the six months of rainfall. Choose your own scale and label both axes.

Science: Where Rain Comes From

BEFORE YOU READ

The water falling on your roof today is not new. There has never been any new water on Earth. As you read, work out where it has been.

- 1 Earth has never made any new water. The water in the puddle outside your classroom is the same water that has been here for billions of years. It has simply been going round and round.
- 2 The Sun heats water in oceans, lakes, rivers and puddles. Some of it turns into an invisible gas called water vapor and rises into the air. This is **evaporation**. It is why a puddle disappears on a warm day without anybody emptying it.
- 3 Higher up, the air is colder. When the vapor cools it turns back into tiny droplets of liquid water, far too small to fall. Billions of these droplets together are what a cloud is. This is **condensation**. It is the same thing that happens on the outside of a cold drink on a hot day.
- 4 The droplets bump into each other and join up. When a droplet becomes heavy enough that the air can no longer hold it, it falls. That is **precipitation**: rain, or snow, or hail, depending on how cold it is on the way down.
- 5 What falls either soaks into the ground or runs downhill into streams and rivers, which carry it back to the sea. That is **collection**. Then the Sun heats it again and the whole thing starts over.
- 6 There is one part people usually miss. Plants do it too. Roots pull water out of the soil and leaves release it back into the air as vapor, which is called **transpiration**. A single large tree can put hundreds of liters of water into the air on a hot day. Forests help make their own rain.
- 7 So the rain that fell on Priya's town could have been in an ocean last month, inside a cloud last week, and inside a tree before that. It has been everywhere, and it keeps going.

WORDS WORTH KNOWING

Vapor water in the form of an invisible gas.

Evaporation liquid turning into vapor.

Condensation vapor turning back into liquid.

Precipitation water falling as rain, snow or hail.

Science: Where Rain Comes From: Your Turn

TASK 1: NAME EACH STAGE

Write the correct word beside each description: **evaporation**, **condensation**, **precipitation**, **collection**, or **transpiration**.

WHAT IS HAPPENING	THE WORD	PAR.
A puddle dries up in the sunshine		
Water droplets join up and fall as rain		
A tree's leaves release water into the air		
Vapor cools high up and forms a cloud		
A river carries water back to the sea		

1 Water appears on the outside of a cold glass on a hot day. Which stage is that, and where did the water come from? It did not leak through the glass.

TASK 2: THE BIG IDEA

Paragraph 1 says Earth has never made any new water. Explain in two or three sentences what that means for the water you drank at lunch today.

FAST FINISHER

Draw the water cycle as a circle with arrows. Label all five stages, including transpiration, which most diagrams leave out.

End of Day Reflection

LAST TEN MINUTES

BEFORE YOU PACK UP

Fill this in on your own. Your teacher will read it tomorrow, so be honest. There are no wrong answers here.

1 One thing I learned today was...

2 One thing I found tricky was...

3 One thing that surprised me today was...

4 Something my teacher should know about today:

This is for anything at all. Good or bad.

A NOTE TO WHOEVER IS READING THIS

Thank you for looking after our class today. Please write your name here so we know who to thank:

Answer Key: Literacy

READING QUESTIONS

1. Any three of: the light turns the color of pond water; everything looks green; the wind stops completely; the flagpole rope goes silent; it is quiet enough to hear a pencil rolling.
2. To keep everyone calm. If he sounded frightened the class would panic, so he uses an ordinary voice on purpose.
Strong students notice that the flat voice is itself frightening, because it is so clearly deliberate. Give extra credit.
3. They were frightened, or at least knew something serious was happening. Normally somebody argues. Nobody did, because everyone could tell this was not a drill.
4. **No.** Paragraph 14 shows her lying awake counting the seconds between lightning and thunder of a harmless storm forty miles away, over and over, until she falls asleep. Someone who was not frightened would not still be checking.
This is the question that carries the lesson. Full credit needs the link between her saying no and her behavior that night. Accept a well-argued "she believes it herself" answer.
5. Any of: counting the four seconds; counting eleven minutes in groups of ten; her hands going cold; putting her hands in her sleeves; counting the seconds during the storm that night.
The counting is the key detail. Priya counts whenever she is frightened, and the story never explains this. Worth pointing out if the class does not spot it.

GO FURTHER AND WRITING

Go further: Open. Strong rewrites keep every fact and change what is noticed: the window, the clock, counting heads, the hallway, whether everyone is accounted for. The best ones make the reader realize how much he was hiding.

MARKING THE WRITING IN TEN SECONDS

The one thing to look for is **showing rather than telling**. If a story says "everyone was scared", write "what did they do?" in the margin. That single question improves more student writing than any other.

IF YOU ONLY MARK ONE THING TODAY

Mark the writing. It is the only piece on the whole day that shows you how each student thinks, and it is the piece the returning teacher can act on fastest.

Everything else can be checked against this key in a few minutes, or simply stacked and left.

Answer Key: Math and Afternoon

MATH PRACTICE

	ANSWER	WORKING
A	5/10, which is exactly half	Half of 10 is 5
B	1/2 is bigger	Double 2 is 4, less than 5, so 2/5 is under a half
1	4/8, exactly half	Half of 8 is 4
2	Less than half	Double 3 is 6, which is less than 8
3	More than half	Double 5 is 10, which is more than 9
4	1/4, 1/2, 3/4	
5	8 students walk	$24 \div 3$
6	6 students come by bus	$24 \div 4$
7	April, with 80 mm	Read from the table
8	60 mm more	$80 - 20$

Challenge: 1. 280 mm (40+30+60+80+50+20). 2. 80/280, which simplifies to 2/7. 3. **True.** February was 30 mm and March was 60 mm, and 30 doubled is 60. Worth noting to the class that the claim is accurate but a bit misleading: doubling a small number still leaves a small number.

AFTERNOON BLOCK

Task 1: Puddle drying = **evaporation** (par. 2). Droplets fall as rain = **precipitation** (par. 4). Leaves release water = **transpiration** (par. 6). Vapor cools into a cloud = **condensation** (par. 3). River carries water to the sea = **collection** (par. 5).

Q1. Condensation. The water came from vapor already in the air around the glass. The cold surface cooled that vapor and turned it back into liquid.

Task 2. The water they drank has been on Earth for billions of years and has been through the cycle countless times. It may have been in an ocean, a cloud, a river or a tree before it reached them, and it will keep going after.

LEAVE THIS FOR THE TEACHER

Stack the day's work on the desk with the End of Day Reflection sheets on top. Those are the most useful thing the returning teacher will read.

Time Filler Bank

SUBSTITUTE • KEEP THIS PAGE. YOU WILL NEED IT.

WHY THIS PAGE EXISTS

An elementary day is full of gaps: five minutes before specials, ten minutes because lunch ran late, the twenty minutes after everyone finishes early. Those gaps are where a class you do not know falls apart.

Nothing below needs any equipment at all. No photocopies, no board, no supplies.

Under five minutes

ACTIVITY	HOW IT WORKS
Twenty questions	You think of an object in the room. They ask yes or no questions. Cap it at twenty and count out loud.
Categories	Name a category (things that are cold, animals with four legs). Go around the room, no repeats. Sit down when you cannot think of one.
Silent line-up	Line up in birthday order, or alphabetical by first name, without speaking. Harder and quieter than it sounds.
Would you rather	Would you rather be able to fly or be invisible? Hands up for each. Ask two children why.
Buzz	Count around the room. Every multiple of three, say buzz instead of the number. Start again at any mistake.

Five to fifteen minutes

ACTIVITY	HOW IT WORKS
The one-minute story	You give three words. Each child writes a story using all three, in one minute exactly. Read two or three aloud.
Guess my rule	Sort children into two groups by a secret rule (wearing laces, has a brother). They guess the rule.
The alphabet challenge	In pairs, name something in the room for every letter. First to reach M wins. Nothing needs writing down.
Two truths and a lie	Each child writes three statements about themselves, one false. Partners guess. Excellent for a class that does not know you.
Story chain	You start a story with one sentence. Each child adds one sentence around the room. Absurd is fine.
Estimation station	How many steps from the door to the window? Everyone estimates, writes it down, then you count together. Genuinely mathematical.
Draw what I say	Describe a simple picture out loud. They draw it without seeing it. Compare at the end. Teaches listening and it is very funny.

If you have longer than fifteen minutes

ACTIVITY	HOW IT WORKS
Class newspaper	In groups, produce a one-page newspaper about today. Reporters, an illustrator, a headline writer. Absorbs a whole class.
Design a country	Each child invents a country: name, flag, one law, one food, one thing it is famous for. Share three at the end.
Silent debate	Write a statement on the board (homework should be banned). Children write agreements and disagreements on paper passed around, without speaking at all.

TWO RULES FOR ANY OF THESE

Say how it ends before it starts, and **do not offer a choice**. Pick one, announce it, run it. Asking thirty children what they would like to play turns a calm ten minutes into a difficult twenty.

Brain Breaks and Transitions

SUBSTITUTE · KEEP THIS PAGE

WHEN TO USE ONE

Children in grades 3 to 5 can concentrate for roughly as many minutes as their age, plus a little. A brain break every twenty to thirty minutes is not lost time. It is what buys you the next twenty.

Signs you need one right now: fidgeting, chairs tipping, three children asking to use the bathroom in a row, or the same question being asked twice.

Sitting down, two minutes

BREAK	WHAT TO DO
Ten and ten	Ten slow shoulder rolls backward, then ten forward. Everyone stays seated.
Follow the leader	You tap a rhythm on the desk; they copy. Get gradually more complicated.
Silent count to twenty	The class counts to twenty aloud, one number per child, no order agreed and no two speaking at once. Start again on a clash. Remarkably absorbing.
Five deep breaths	In for four counts, out for six. Genuinely calms a room before a written task.

Standing up, three to five minutes

BREAK	WHAT TO DO
Simon says	Works from grade 3 to grade 5 without fail. Speed it up to make it harder.
Four corners	Name the corners 1 to 4. Call a number, everyone moves. Call them faster.
Freeze dance, no music	You clap a beat, they move; you stop, they freeze. No equipment needed.
Stretch and reach	Reach up for ten, touch toes for ten, twist left and right for ten.
Cross-body taps	Right hand to left knee, left hand to right knee, twenty times. Crossing the midline genuinely helps students refocus.

GETTING THEM BACK

Always announce how it ends before it starts. "When I raise my hand, we are back in our seats and ready." A brain break without a stated ending is just noise you now have to fix.

Indoor Recess Bank

SUBSTITUTE • FOR THE DAY IT RAINS

INDOOR RECESS IS THE HARDEST PART OF A COVER DAY

The children expect free time, you do not know the rules, and the room is not designed for it. Pick **one** activity from below, announce it clearly, and run it for the whole period. Offering choices is what turns indoor recess into chaos.

Whole class, no equipment

GAME	HOW IT WORKS
Heads down, thumbs up	Four children are chosen. Everyone else puts heads down, thumb up. The four each press one thumb. Those chosen guess who picked them. Quiet, and they will play it for forty minutes.
Silent ball	Roll or gently pass a soft object. Anyone who speaks or drops it sits out. Requires almost nothing from you.
The detective game	One child leaves. The class picks a leader who starts actions everyone copies. The detective returns and works out who the leader is.
Charades by table	Tables take turns acting out an animal, a sport or a job. Keep it to twenty seconds each.
Hangman or word ladders	On the board. Let a child run it while you supervise. They enjoy it far more than you running it.

At desks, quieter

- **Drawing challenge.** Draw the classroom from the ceiling looking down. Genuinely difficult and absorbing.
- **Paper only.** Fold and design a paper airplane, but no throwing until the last five minutes, outside if allowed.
- **Word building.** Write a long word on the board and see how many smaller words they can make from its letters.
- **Dots and boxes, or noughts and crosses.** In pairs, on scrap paper. Unfashionable and completely reliable.

TWO RULES TO STATE AT THE START

Everyone stays in the room, and when you raise your hand the game stops instantly. Say both before you start, not after something goes wrong.

Fast Finisher Menu

COPY THIS PAGE FOR STUDENTS

FINISHED ALREADY?

Choose any box below. You do not need to ask permission and you do not have to do them in order. Use the back of this sheet or a piece of scrap paper.

TRY THIS

- 1 Write a letter to your teacher telling them what happened today. Include one thing that went well and one thing that was tricky.
- 2 Invent a new animal that lives somewhere very cold. Draw it and label four things that help it survive.
- 3 Write the numbers 1 to 20 down the side of a page. Next to each one, write a multiplication that makes it. Some are impossible with whole numbers. Which ones?
- 4 Design a machine that does one boring job for you. Draw it, label the parts, and write one sentence saying how it works.
- 5 Write a story that is exactly six sentences long. Beginning, middle and end.
- 6 Look around the room and find five things shaped like a rectangle. Estimate the area of each one, then say which estimate you are least sure about.
- 7 Write ten questions you would ask someone who lived a hundred years ago.
- 8 Choose a word with at least eight letters. How many smaller words can you make from its letters? Beat twenty.
- 9 Draw a map of the route from your classroom to the school gate. Label five things along the way.
- 10 Write down three things you are genuinely good at, and one thing you would like to get better at this year.

STILL FINISHED?

Read your book quietly, or help someone at your table who is stuck. Helping means asking them questions, not giving them the answer.

Substitute's Note Back

SUBSTITUTE • FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU LEAVE

THREE THINGS, THEN YOU ARE DONE

1. Stack the day's work on the teacher's desk with the End of Day Reflection sheets on top.
2. Name two or three children who genuinely helped. Teachers act on this, and the children find out.
3. Write one line about anything the teacher should know. One line. Not a report.

NOTE BACK TO THE TEACHER

My name

Day taught

Day 1 / Day 2 / Day 3

We got through

All of it / Most of it / The morning only

What we did not reach

Children who helped

Anything you should know

One line is plenty

Would I come back?

Yes, gladly / Yes / Probably not, and here is why:

A NOTE TO THE RETURNING TEACHER

The most useful thing in the pile is not the worksheets. It is the stack of End of Day Reflection sheets, where each child has written what they learned, what was tricky, and anything you should know. Read those first. They take four minutes and they will tell you more about the day than any of the work.

Standards Alignment

COMMON CORE AND NGSS • GRADES 3-5

Each block is mapped to its primary standard. Because the pack spans a grade band, standards are given at grade 4 and apply with light adjustment across 3 to 5.

DAY	BLOCK	FOCUS	STANDARD
1	Reading	Citing evidence from informational text	RI.4.1, RI.4.3
1	Writing	Opinion writing with reasons and evidence	W.4.1
1	Math	Multiplication, arrays and area	3.MD.C.7, 4.MD.A.3
1	Science	Structure, function and survival	4-LS1-1
2	Reading	Cause and effect in informational text	RI.4.3, RI.4.5
2	Writing	Explanatory writing with linking words	W.4.2
2	Math	Perimeter, and perimeter versus area	4.MD.A.3
2	Science	Forces, structures and engineering design	3-PS2-1, 3-5-ETS1-2
3	Reading	Inference and character in literature	RL.4.1, RL.4.3
3	Writing	Narrative writing with descriptive detail	W.4.3
3	Math	Fractions, comparison and reading data	4.NF.A.2, 4.MD.B.4
3	Science	The water cycle	5-ESS2-1

Also practiced every day

- Reading fluency and vocabulary in context, through the morning word work
- Multiplication and division fact recall, through the morning number warm-up
- Reflection and self-assessment, through the End of Day Reflection sheet

A NOTE ON STANDARDS

These are complete instructional days, not curriculum coverage. They are designed to be genuinely useful on a day the regular teacher is absent, without depending on where a class has reached in its own sequence. Every day stands alone.

Standards references are provided to help teachers document the day's instruction. This resource is independently created and is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or reviewed by any state agency or standards body.

Terms of Use and Credits

THANK YOU

Thank you for buying this pack. It was written by a practicing teacher with more than twenty years in classrooms, and built the way I would want a full day of cover built if I were the one waking up sick at half past five.

If it saved you a morning, a rating on the listing genuinely helps other teachers find it, and earns you credit toward your next purchase.

Getting the most out of this pack

- **Print all three days before you need them.** The whole point is that it works on a morning when you cannot get to school to print anything.
- **Copy each day as one stapled packet.** Twelve student pages per day. Handing out one packet removes most of the transitions where an unfamiliar class comes apart.
- **Store it in two piles.** Student packets in one, the Day at a Glance pages, scripts and answer keys in the other.
- **Fill in the Class Information page once,** at the start of the year, and it works for every absence after.
- **Tell your office where it is.** On a genuine emergency day, the person who needs to find this is not you.
- **Use the filler banks when you are present too.** The brain breaks and indoor recess pages work on any wet Wednesday.

Terms of use

You may: print this pack for your own classroom, as many times as you like, for as many years as you like. Photocopy the student pages freely for your own students and leave the pack for a substitute covering your own class.

You may not: share the file with colleagues, upload it to a school drive, district server, or any public website, resell it, or claim it as your own work. Additional licenses for colleagues are available at a discount on the listing page.

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